tenance practice similar to what Japan has for its high-speed trains." For this, the railways used the focused group discussion (FGD) method, where feedback is sought directly from passengers. The exercise went on for months, using zonal railway officials, vendors and even the Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation (IRCTC). "We obtained feedback from multiple sources. Officers travelled in the trains and had conversations with passengers to learn what they liked and what they did not, and why," explains Vaishnaw. "Then we looked at the root cause of the issues to address them. We are also institutionalising a rapid feedback mechanism for product design and service delivery. This is a new area for the Indian Railways."

Realising that no train service is good enough if passengers are complaining about things as basic as seats and AC and lights, the maximum interventions have come in these areas in the new Vande Bharat rakes. So train seats are now 25 per cent softer, recline more up to 19 degrees and come in a "pleasant blue" shade (passenger felt the earlier red was "too bright" and "didn't look good"). The roller blinds on the windows are now thicker and let in less light. The 'air-tightness' inside the coaches has been bolstered with rubber panels for better AC cooling.

The toilets in trains have been a perennial source of complaints, and Vande Bharat had its share too. Despite the modern design, passengers found three peculiar problems. Somehow the toilet floor was always wet, the lights were too dim and the taps gushed out water. Looking into the plaints, the engineers realised the wash basins were too shallow, splashing water every time someone opened the tap. So, a new deeper design was approved, the taps were fitted with aerators for better flow control and light bulbs were changed to 2.5 W to provide better illumination.

Together with these, there have been some 25 big and small modifications in the new set of nine Vande Bharat trains (see *Gaining Traction*). A significant change has been in the colour. The signature white with a deep blue band has been changed to a bright orange. "Globally, this is among the most popular colours for high-speed trains as it is low on maintenance and high on visibility," says Vaishnaw. There is also something called the '14 minute miracle cleaning' now. Launched on October 1 as part of the government's *swachhata* push, the new protocol aims to cut down train cleaning time to just 14 minutes. The fast-cleaning drill will cut the turnaround time of the Vande Bharat trains, say railway officials.

THOU SHALT NOT BE LATE

Along with the modifications, Indian Railways is also cultivating a new work culture within its ranks. Monitoring now is at the "highest level", with some divisional railway managers in Central, West Central and other zones getting calls from the minister in Delhi, asking why the Vande Bharats in their areas ran late on certain days. "Every time a Vande Bharat misses its arrival time, the ministry seeks an explanation from zonal officials. This is to drive home the message that these trains must not see a single complaint related to punctuality," says a railway official. The most popular Vande Bharat service, between Thiruvananthapuram and Kasargod in Kerala, with over 170 per cent occupancy, has run late only twice since its launch in April. "The two times it was late was due to track obstructions. Once there was a dead body on the track," says a senior official of the Thiruvanantha-

SMOOTHING OUT THE GLITCHES



THE PLAINT: Train colour was a signature white with blue band

THE FIX: Changed to bright orange, a "globally popular colour" for high-speed trains as it is low on maintenance and high on visibility

THE PLAINT: India's old tracks have too many speed restrictions due to engineering challenges on the tracks like curvature and weak beds

THE FIX: The zonal railways asked to work on track infrastructure on priority so that all trains can increase average speeds



THE PLAINT: Toilet floors always wet, lights too dim and the taps were gushing water

THE FIX: Deeper sinks to stop splashing on floor, brighter bulbs and taps fitted with aerators for controlled flow